Customer Interview Kit

Everything for 10 customer conversations in one doc: your problem sentence, who to ask, outreach messages, a timed script, red flags and a notes form.

FREE | 45 MIN | PLAYBOOK: VALIDATION INTERVIEW SCRIPTS

YOU WALK AWAY WITH
A one-sentence problem, 10 named people, outreach you actually sent and a page of notes in their words for every conversation.

USE IT
Start track weeks 1 and 2 before you build anything, or Build and Grow week 1 for the best-customer script.

Ten real conversations teach you more than a month of research. This kit holds all of it: the problem sentence, the people, the messages, the script and the notes.

Give it 45 minutes to fill Steps 1 to 3 and send your first messages. Each call then takes about 20 minutes with notes. Ask about the past. Never pitch.

Step 1: Your problem in one sentence

Write the problem before you look for people. Use the words a customer would say, not industry jargon.

> [Who] struggles with [problem] when [situation], and today they [current fix].

Who

One specific person. "College seniors applying to finance internships", not "job seekers".

Problem

What hurts, in plain words

Situation

When it shows up

Current fix

What they do or pay today

Your sentence

Put it together and read it out loud. Would they say "that's me"?

> “Focus on solving a problem before building a solution.”
>
> ELI

Step 2: Find 10 people who have it

Names, not personas. Talk to people who have the problem now, or who paid to fix it recently. Not friends who will just be nice.

- Social posts: find people complaining about it on Instagram, TikTok or X. Comment first, then DM.
- Reddit: your city, your college or the hobby, like r/Sneakers. Message people who posted about it.
- Campus: clubs, career centers, dorm group chats and Discord servers. Ask a leader if you can post.
- Family friends: ask parents, coaches and old teachers, "Who do you know who deals with this?"
- Local businesses: walk in during a slow hour. Be respectful and specific.
- Every call: end with "Who else do you know who deals with this?"

> “Talk to everyone, everywhere, every time.”
>
> ELI

List them here, then message three of them today.

Name or handle	Where you found them	Date messaged	Booked?

Stuck at four names? Ask those four who else deals with this. Prefer a sheet? Log everyone in the Conversation Tracker.

Step 3: Send the ask

Short, honest and easy to say yes to. You're asking to learn, not to sell. Never pretend to be a researcher, and never pitch after promising you won't.

FIRST ASK COPY

```
Hey [name], I saw your [post/comment] about [problem].
I'm [first name]. I'm starting a small business around [problem area], and I'm trying to learn how people deal with it right now.
Would you be open to a 15-minute call or a few voice notes this week?
I'm not selling anything. I just want to understand it from someone who's actually dealt with it.
Totally fine if not. Thanks either way.
```

FOLLOW-UP (ONCE, 3 DAYS LATER) COPY

```
Hey [name], bumping this in case it got buried.
I'd still love to hear how you handle [problem]. Even 10 minutes helps.
If now's a bad time, no worries at all.
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ASK FOR AN INTRO COPY

```
Hey [name], quick favor.
I'm talking to people who deal with [problem] to learn how they handle it. I'm not selling anything.
Do you know one person who deals with this and might give me 15 minutes?
I can send you a short message to forward.
```

> Follow up once, not five times. A no is fine. Silence is fine. Move to the next name.

Step 4: Run the call

Ask about the past, not the future. Never pitch. Write down their exact words. Want to record? Ask first, every time.

INTERVIEW SCRIPT (15 MINUTES) COPY

```
OPEN (1 min)
Thanks for doing this. I'm trying to understand how people deal with [problem]. There are no wrong
answers, and I'm not selling anything today.

CONTEXT (2 min)
1. Tell me a bit about you and how [problem area] shows up in your life or work.

THE PROBLEM (5 min)
2. Tell me about the last time you dealt with [problem]. What happened?
3. How often does this come up?
4. What's the hardest part about it?

HOW THEY SOLVE IT TODAY (5 min)
5. How are you solving this right now? Walk me through it.
6. What did you try before that? What happened?
7. What does it cost you, in money, time or stress?
8. What do you like and hate about what you use now?

CLOSE (2 min)
9. If you could wave a magic wand and fix one thing about this, what would it be?
10. Who else do you know who deals with this?
11. Can I follow up with you if I build something?
```

Dig deeper when an answer is vague

- Can you tell me more about that?
- Why was that frustrating?
- What did you do next?
- How much did you pay for that? How much time did it take?
- When was the last time that happened?
- What would happen if you just didn't solve it? ("Nothing much" means the pain may be small.)
- Then stay quiet for three seconds. People fill silence with the honest part.

Red flags: tick any after each call

- [ ] They complimented the idea. Polite, not proof.
- [ ] They said "I'd totally buy that." Future promises are cheap.
- [ ] They said "someone should make that" but never tried to fix it.
- [ ] I asked "would you…" instead of "when did you last…"
- [ ] I talked more than they did.
- [ ] I explained or pitched my idea.
- [ ] They're a friend or family member who wants me to win.

Two or more ticked? Count the call as weak evidence and tighten the next one.

Step 5: Notes form

Fill this in right after each call, while it's fresh. Duplicate this page for every interview, or log each one in the Conversation Tracker. Their words, not your summary. Granola can take call notes for you, but write the exact phrases yourself.

Interview # and date

Who they are

Name, role, where you found them

How they solve it today

Exact steps or tools

What they pay today

Money, time or both. Real numbers.

Hardest part, in their words

Exact quote

Phrases worth stealing

Two more exact quotes

Tried before

What, and why it failed

Magic wand answer

Pain level, 1 to 5

Your judgment. 1 is a shrug. 5 is already paying for a fix or building their own.

Red flags ticked

Referrals

Names they gave you

OK to follow up?

Yes or no

FILLED EXAMPLE

a sneaker cleaning service

Problem sentence: College sneakerheads struggle to clean suede when a pair gets dirty, and today they use dish soap or wait a week at a shop.

Interview #3 / Oct 14
Who they are: Sam, college sophomore. Posted in r/Sneakers about ruined suede.
How they solve it today: a YouTube tutorial, dish soap and an old toothbrush.
What they pay today: $35 at a mall shop last spring, plus 5 days without the shoes.
Hardest part: "I don't trust myself with suede."
Phrases worth stealing: "I just stopped wearing them." / "A week is way too long."
Tried before: a cleaning kit. It left water stains.
Magic wand: "Someone picks them up and they're clean by the weekend."
Pain level: 4
Red flags ticked: none
Referrals: her roommate, Dev
OK to follow up? Yes

Build and Grow: talk to your best customers

Already selling? Talk to three of your best or most recent customers. No customers yet? Run the main script with three prospects. Same rules: past behavior, their words, no pitching.

BEST-CUSTOMER SCRIPT (10 MINUTES) COPY

```
Thanks for buying, and for doing this. I want to learn what made it worth it, so I can do more of what works.

1. What was going on when you started looking for this?
2. Why did you buy from me instead of something else?
3. What almost stopped you from buying?
4. What would you tell a friend it does?
5. What would make it a no-brainer to buy again or recommend?
6. Who else do you know who should have this?
```

> Their answer to question 4 is often a better headline than yours. Their answer to question 3 belongs in your FAQ. Quote anyone by name only with permission.

Next step

After your 10 conversations, open the Interview Synthesis sheet. Put all your notes side by side, find the phrases that repeat, and decide: kill, pause or double down.

Make today day one.

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